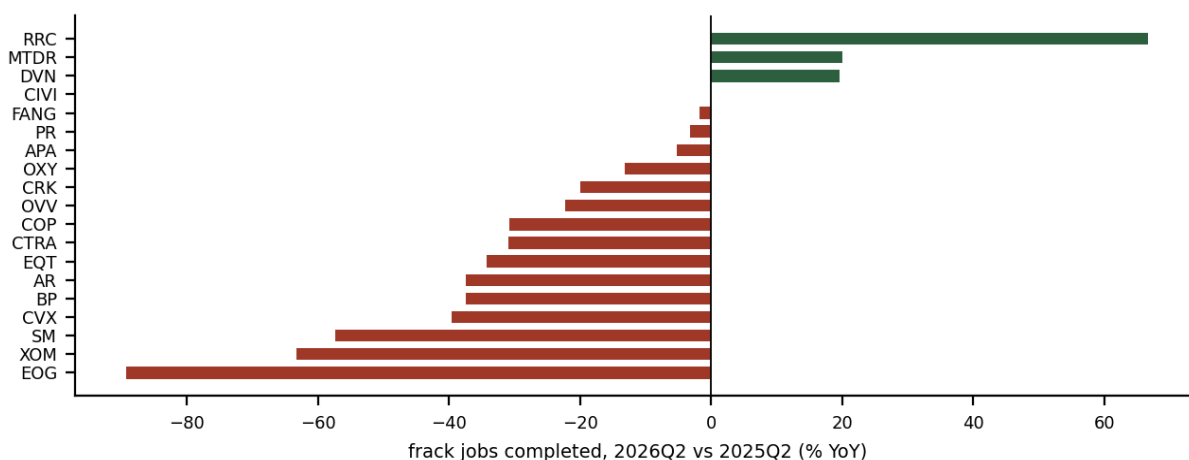


Completion Velocity: FracFocus Disclosures as an Operator-Level Activity Signal for Shale E&Ps

Alt-data research note · Michael Miele · July 18, 2026 · FracFocus registry through July 13, 2026 (248K disclosures)

Data and signal construction

Every hydraulic-fracturing job in the US must be disclosed to the FracFocus registry with operator, well, job dates, and base-water volume. I normalized the full bulk export — **248K disclosures, 2012–present, 2,035 operators** — to monthly completion counts and water volumes per operator, then mapped operators to 32 listed tickers using **ownership windows** so M&A never miscredits activity: Pioneer counts as PXD until April 2024 and as XOM after; Endeavor is private until Diamondback closes; Marathon→COP, Hess/PDC/Noble→CVX, Chesapeake+Southwestern→EXE, CrownRock→OXY each switch at deal close. The signal is quarterly YoY growth in completed jobs per ticker. Completions lead first production by roughly a quarter, so operator-level completion acceleration is a candidate leading indicator for reported production and capex. Key friction, respected throughout: disclosures are *filed* 30–90 days after job end, so the most recent quarter is always partially visible.



Pre-committed return test: an honest null, with a named bias

Cross-sectional tertile test over 45 quarters (2015Q1–2026Q1, ≥ 6 names/quarter): rank by jobs YoY growth, hold months 2–4 after quarter end (when filings are complete). Result: **-0.66%/quarter top-minus-bottom, permutation $p = 0.80$** — no return predictability. Two disclosed limitations: (1) **survivorship** — Yahoo lacks history for 12 tickers, ten of them delisted via takeover *after outperforming* (PXD, HES, MRO...), which biases the test toward null; (2) in shale, activity growth is not value creation — completion acceleration can be capital-destructive, so the natural use is production-surprise forecasting, not raw return ranking.

Current board and pre-registered check

2026Q2 completion momentum (partial data): **Range Resources +67%, Matador +20%, Devon +20% YoY** against broad declines elsewhere (EOG -89% and XOM -63% are partly filing-lag artifacts). **Check in September 2026**, when Q2 filings are complete: (1) does the RRC/MTDR/DVN acceleration survive final data? (2) do their Q3 production prints beat consensus? Logged before either is knowable.

Pipeline: github.com/michaelmiele07/alt-data-frac-activity — fetch → normalize (ownership windows) → quarterly signal → permutation validation. FracFocus data is public. Research, not investment advice. Third entry in a regulatory-exhaust series (NHTSA complaints, CFPB complaints, FracFocus disclosures).